

Chapter 98-4

A few seconds later, Shen Hui got up to get dressed. Her body was covered in marks left by Zhao Xuning's tormenting—especially on her shoulders and back.

Shen Hui often said Zhao Xuning was like a dog, always gnawing and biting in bed. Though her tongue was indeed quite skilled, flexible like a snake.

Shen Hui was also difficult in bed, but back then Zhao Xuning was willing to indulge her.

When she was difficult at other times, Zhao Xuning couldn't be bothered to indulge her.

So when Shen Hui got up and finished dressing, Zhao Xuning asked where she was going.

Shen Hui didn't argue with her. She just said sullenly, "To buy dumplings."

But she had been worn out too thoroughly the night before. It happened to be after Zhao Xuning had been hungover the previous night, so she had been many times rougher than usual. As a result, Shen Hui's hunger was also many times worse than before.

She really couldn't take it anymore. She was so hungry that she cried from feeling wronged.

When had she ever suffered this kind of grievance?

Moreover, Shen Hui's legs were still trembling as she walked. Zhao Xuning lay in bed watching, her heart aching. She reached over to the side of the bed for a hair tie, tied up her hair, and then called out to Shen Hui in that cool, cold voice of hers, "Come back."

Shen Hui didn't look at her. She said petulantly, "What for? You're not going to buy it for me anyway."

Zhao Xuning quickly threw on her clothes and directly princess-carried Shen Hui back to bed. She was so frustrated she bit Shen Hui's lip, then took off her clothes and covered her with the blanket. "My little ancestor,¹ you rest. I'll go buy it."

Lying in bed, Shen Hui said, "I want mushroom filling."

Zhao Xuning frowned. "That stuff doesn't smell good at all. I don't understand why you like eating it."

Shiitake mushrooms, cilantro—foods with "fragrant" in their Chinese names were all excluded from Zhao Xuning's diet.²

But Shen Hui really liked them. She also liked fennel.

When Zhao Xuning first met her, Shen Hui had introduced herself by saying, "My name is Shen Hui—the 'hui' from fennel."³

Although Zhao Xuning was complaining, she still went out to buy it for Shen Hui in the end. Then she didn't let her get out of bed, instead squatting beside her like a human table, serving her while she ate.

Shen Hui had a small mouth and couldn't finish one in a single bite. Zhao Xuning would feed the remaining half to herself.

Shen Hui said to her, "I thought you didn't like eating mushrooms?"

"After you've eaten it, I don't think it's so hard to eat anymore." Zhao Xuning said.

Shen Hui kicked her with her foot, saying she was stealing her food.

Zhao Xuning just smiled without saying anything.

Shen Hui said she wanted to eat, but she didn't eat much. When Zhao Xuning held food up to her mouth with chopsticks, she would shake her head and say she was full.

So Zhao Xuning would coax her. "Be good, eat one more."

And Shen Hui would eat it.

Then one after another, until Shen Hui kept shaking her head. Zhao Xuning would coax her, "Wife, one last one."

Back then, she would always call Shen Hui "wife," "baby," "darling," "Huihui," "A-Hui"—all sorts of intimate nicknames.

Shen Hui liked to call her "Ningning," "Zhao Xuning," "Ningning wife," "Ningning darling"—whatever was most intimate.

No matter how angry Zhao Xuning got, she never dared to raise her voice when calling Shen Hui, and she never dared to call her by her full name.

Every time Zhao Xuning called Shen Hui by her full name was in bed, in the heat of passion. She liked to press close to Shen Hui's ear and whisper, "Shen Hui, I love you so much."

She would only be like this after drinking too much—always lingering and romantic, her tone tender as she spoke the two characters "Shen Hui."

It made Shen Hui want to kiss her so badly, and then the two of them would begin their wanton activities.

That day, after Shen Hui had eaten her fill, Zhao Xuning cleaned up the mess and returned to bed. Shen Hui burrowed into her arms. Zhao Xuning was so exasperated she bit her nose. "So I can't even call you difficult now?"

Shen Hui whined softly in a spoiled manner. "I was starving and feeling so wronged, and you're still criticizing me."

Zhao Xuning laughed. "My wife is just difficult."

"Do you like it or not?"

Zhao Xuning held her tight, then gently bit her lip and said in a muffled voice, "If I didn't like it, would I have gone so far to buy you breakfast?"

Shen Hui smiled.

Later, Zhao Xuning bought breakfast for Shen Hui many times. Each time, when Shen Hui couldn't eat anymore, she would always coax her softly, "Darling, eat one more."

"Wife, one last one."

"....."

She had heard words like these thousands of times, but this was the first time she heard, "Shen Hui, eat one more."

Once upon a time, whenever the two characters "Shen Hui" came from Zhao Xuning's mouth, they were always followed by "I love you so much."

Now, everything had changed.⁴

Shen Hui was dazed for two seconds. Zhao Xuning directly held the food up to her mouth with chopsticks. Shen Hui instinctively opened her mouth and bit down, leaving half remaining.

Zhao Xuning kept holding it there.

Liang Shi had been eating breakfast guiltily when Xu Qingzhu reached under the table and pinched her waist. Liang Shi glanced at her, and Xu Qingzhu frantically signaled her with her eyes.

When she looked up, she saw Zhao Xuning acting as if she were serving an ancestor. While Shen Hui was chewing her food, Zhao Xuning was gazing at her with eyes full of deep affection, not daring to relax the movement of her hands at all.

That gaze was so intense it could practically draw threads between them.⁵

Footnotes:

¹ "My little ancestor" (祖宗, zǔzōng): A term of endearment (sometimes exasperated) used to address someone who is being demanding or difficult to please, implying they're being treated like royalty or a precious ancestor who must be catered to.

² In Chinese, shiitake mushrooms (香菇, xiānggū) and cilantro/coriander (香菜, xiāngcài) both have the character 香 (xiāng, meaning "fragrant") in their names, despite many people finding their actual smells unpleasant. Zhao Xuning is making a joke about how these "fragrant" foods don't actually smell good to her.

³ Shen Hui's given name 茴 (huí) is the same character used in 茴香 (huíxiāng), meaning fennel. This is a common way Chinese people introduce themselves—by explaining which characters make up their name using well-known words.

⁴ "Everything had changed" (物是人非, wù shì rén fēi): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "things remain but people have changed," expressing the melancholy feeling when familiar places or objects remain the same but the people or relationships associated with them have changed.

⁵ "Draw threads" (拉絲, lā sī): This expression describes an intensely lingering gaze, like melted cheese that stretches into threads when pulled apart. It suggests a look so full of emotion and longing that it seems to create a visible connection between two people.